

Flatwoods

PHOTO BY MATTHEW MRIZEK



IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Flatwoods, especially in Georgia's Coastal Plain, were historically dominated by longleaf pine and played a central role in the naval stores industry, producing tar, pitch, and turpentine essential for shipbuilding and trade.

As markets shifted, these lands were widely established into loblolly and slash pine planted forests, helping establish timber as Georgia's top agricultural product. The flat, accessible terrain of flatwoods made them well-suited for mechanized logging, but early practices like ditching and bedding often damaged native ecosystems.

Today, flatwoods remain economically important while gaining recognition for their ecological value. Modern forestry incorporates prescribed fire and adheres to Georgia Best Management Practices (BMPs) to support restoration and sustainability.

SWAP Priority Habitat

Ecoregion(s)

Calcareous Flatwoods (Hardwood Flats)

Southwestern Appalachians/
Ridge & Valley

Pine Flatwoods

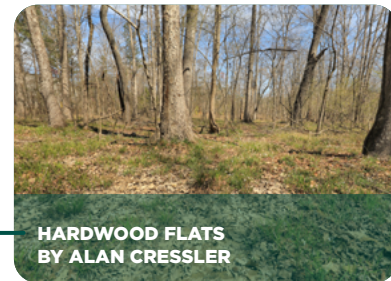
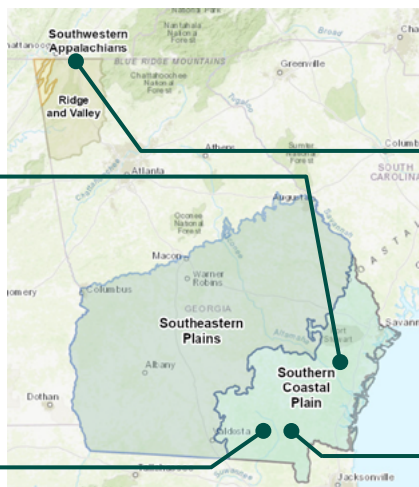
Southeastern Plain/Southern Coastal Plain

Wet Oak Flats

Southern Coastal Plain

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

Coastal Plain flatwoods are characterized by flat to gently rolling topography, seasonally saturated and poorly drained clayey, loamy, and sandy soils, and historically frequent low-intensity fire. Rarer calcareous flatwoods of the Ridge and Valley (along the Conasauga, Coosawattee, Oostanaula, and Coosa rivers) are characterized by very poorly drained, deep calcareous clay soils that experience inundation and saturation in winter followed by extreme drying and cracking in summer.



THREATS

- Habitat loss, degradation, and fragmentation, including clearing and conversion of habitat to agriculture, and residential and commercial development
- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Alterations to hydrology such as ditching, draining, filling in wetlands, and water impoundments
- Invasion of exotic pest plants and animals
- Firebreaks, roads, and ruts caused by heavy vehicle traffic interrupt the natural progression of fire, change hydrology, and reduce movement of wildlife.
- Overstocked stands can degrade habitat by creating closed canopy conditions and reducing sunlight on the ground.

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Avoid bedding, mechanical site preparation, and other soil disturbance.
- Use selective spot herbicide and mechanical treatments to control exotic pest plants.
- Reduce invasion by woody vegetation utilizing prescribed fire on a 2-3-year rotation or with selective spot applications of herbicide if prescribed fire management is not an option.
- Maintain open canopy through selective thinning, if needed.
- If implementing prescribed burning, try to use existing boundary roads and natural features as fire breaks to minimize soil disturbance.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard for more information and resources



SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species via QR code to left